

Ministry of Water, Land and Resource Stewardship

Flood Watch – Bulkley River

High Streamflow Advisory – Skeena (NEW), Central Coast, Northern Interior

Issued: 5:30 PM May 7, 2026

The River Forecast Centre is maintaining a Flood Watch for:

- Bulkley River and tributaries around Smithers and Houston (MAINTAINED)

The River Forecast Centre is issuing or maintaining a High Streamflow Advisory for areas including:

- Skeena River and tributaries around Terrace and Kitsumkalum (NEW)
- Central Coast including the Atnarko River, Bella Coola River and surrounding tributaries (MAINTAINED)
- Lakes Region and tributary rivers around Burns Lake, Fraser Lake, Fort St. James and surrounding areas (MAINTAINED)
- Omineca including tributaries between Prince George and Mackenzie (MAINTAINED)

Weather Synopsis:

An extended period of high pressure has brought seasonally hot temperatures across British Columbia for the past several days. Although temperatures are expected to cool slightly into the weekend, daily maximum temperatures through the northern interior are expected to reach or exceed 20°C, with overnight low temperatures remaining above freezing in many locations. A low pressure system is expected to bring light to moderate (possibly locally heavy) precipitation to the North and Central coasts over the weekend. Snowmelt rates observed at Automated Snow Weather Stations in the region have generally been in the 15 to 30 mm range over the past few days, higher in some locations.

River Conditions:

Rivers have been rising in response to hot temperatures and snowmelt. Several rivers at Water Survey of Canada (WSC) real-time monitoring locations are currently flowing near or above a mean annual peak flow level (i.e. 2-year flow).

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Flows in rivers throughout the region are forecast to remain elevated through at least the next several days. In the short term, additional rises from snowmelt may be somewhat limited by slightly cooler air temperatures, but rainfall could boost flows. Multiple locations could remain at, reach, or exceed the 2-year to 5-year flow through today and tomorrow. Low-lying flooding and bank erosion are possible at these levels. The Bulkley River near Smithers (08EE005) gauge is currently at a water level of approx. 5.0 m (800 m³/s). The Skeena River at Usk (08EF001) gauge is currently at a water level of approx. 9.3 m (3,660 m³/s). However, the WSC indicates that this gauge was relocated in January 2025, meaning historical water level thresholds may not be directly comparable to current near-real-time observations, adding uncertainty in assessing potential impacts. Flows may exceed flood stage on the Bulkley River, the Skeena River, and other headwater areas.

Fast-flowing rivers pose increased risk to safety. Stay away from rivers and river banks, which can be unstable. Never drive through floodwaters, as unseen hazards and current can be life-threatening.

The [River Forecast Centre](#) continues to monitor the conditions and will provide updates as conditions warrant.

For information on how to prepare for flood hazards, visit [PreparedBC](#).

BC River Forecast Centre

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A **High Streamflow Advisory** means that river levels are rising or expected to rise rapidly, but that no major flooding is expected. Fast-flowing bodies of water increase risk to life safety. Minor flooding in low-lying areas is possible.

A **Flood Watch** means that river levels are rising and will approach or may exceed bankfull. Flooding of areas adjacent to affected rivers may occur.

A **Flood Warning** means that river levels have exceeded bankfull or will exceed bankfull imminently, and that flooding of areas adjacent to the rivers affected will result.